

Evolving expectations from GCs and CROs in TMT sector

(AI, trust, talent and global political matters in focus)



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For most organisations in the world, the past 12 months might have felt like a 100-metre sprint as they balanced the pace of innovation and expansion amid surging regulatory changes and increased risk exposure. This is more evident in the technology, media and telecommunications (TMT) sector, where general counsels (GCs) and chief risk and compliance officers (CROs) are doing the heavy lifting and contributing significantly towards navigating regulatory risk and driving business reinvention.

India has emerged as a global tech hub with large scale digital platforms, infrastructure and talent; and these roles have become significantly strategic.

PwC's 29th Global CEO Survey (2026) and the Global Workforce Hopes and Fears Survey (2025) indicate that TMT companies face a dual reality, where:

- (a) The world is witnessing high levels of innovation especially in AI (38% of TMT CEOs reported AI driven revenue growth in the past year and 54% of the respondents said that their workforce is confident that they'll be able to control how technology will affect their work in the next three years)
- (b) The world is grappling with increased risks around cyber threats (31% of CEOs report high exposure), prompting 84% respondents to strengthen cybersecurity amid geopolitical matters. 51% of CEOs are planning global expansion of their business and India is one of their top 3 choices. All this exposes organisations to address new regulatory challenges. Additionally, stakeholder trust risks are also increasing, with 66% of CEOs identifying trust-related matters across at least one area of operations.

The surveys' findings are important for GCs and CROs in the TMT sector due to:

1. **Evolving risks and regulation:** Organisations are increasingly concerned about threats like economic instability, cyberattacks, and geopolitical conflicts. TMT sector often sits at the intersection of these aspects due to the multi-country footprint of the sector. Indian ITeS companies, telecom operators, media platforms, and global capability centres (GCCs) are exposed to global geopolitics, balancing partnerships between various countries and stakeholders, via trade agreements. This also means managing exposure to export controls and sanctions rules, tariff uncertainty, and supply chain realignments, especially in semiconductors, telecom equipment, and AI. TMT is a critical node in worldwide digital set-ups, making it a target for cybercrime, and state linked actors.
2. **AI adoption and innovation with guardrails:** TMT sector is leading in AI adoption with GenAI solutions embedded across the sector's operations such as software development, customer support, content enhancement, ad tech, network optimisation, and enterprise SaaS platforms that are exported worldwide.

Without a dedicated AI law, India's responsible AI framework relies on a complex web of existing regulations such as the IT Act, BNS, DPDP Act, and sectoral guidance from RBI, SEBI, TRAI, and ICMR alongside international frameworks like the EU AI Act and U.S. Executive Order 14110. This multi-layered approach is driving greater transparency and accountability.

Organisations are also reinventing business models through AI and sectoral convergence. The entry of global AI into traditional IT services, backed by private equity and consulting firms will rewrite the future.

3. **Stakeholder trust and workforce transformation:** As concerns related to personal and sensitive information, AI bias, and content integrity in media persist, factors such as trust in stakeholders, ethics, and employee confidence are helping organisations in achieving the desired required business results. The workforce survey reveals that tech-sector employees demonstrate above-average trust and alignment when leadership gets things right.

Three key takeaways for TMT GCs and CROs

1. **Legal and compliance as a strategic enabler of innovation, not just a gatekeeper:**

The legal and compliance function should advise the C-suite on regulatory matters for new digital products, structuring deals in new industries and sectors, and driving contracts negotiations. By providing clear guidance and focusing on anticipatory actions for new products and markets, GCs and CRO can turn compliance into a competitive asset.

2. **Risk management as an 'always-on' intelligence capability across cyber, global geopolitical, and regulatory risks:**

TMT sector's risk and compliance teams should broaden their risk radar and strategy to address evolving threats. They should also collaborate across functions such as IT, security, finance, and HR to anticipate threats and respond quickly whether it's a data breach by the cloud provider or a change in content moderation law for a media platform. A unified global GRC platform, powered by reliable, real time intelligence such as **PwC's Compliance Insights**, enables leadership teams to anticipate risk, make informed business calls, and respond with speed and confidence as the operating environment evolves.

3. **Trust as the new currency and talent as strategic asset will give a competitive edge in AI-driven business models:**

GCs and CROs need to champion transparency and ethical practices to ensure that values ranging from data privacy commitments to diversity and inclusion goals are translated from guidance to practice. Building trust also requires clarity and transparency in how innovation is governed along with collaboration with HR and business leaders to establish clear policies on intellectual property ownership of employee driven innovations. Transparent and ethical frameworks for AI usage will reinforce trust and confidence in business decisions among employees and stakeholders alike.

GCs and CROs in 2029

Technology alone can't guarantee success. It must be accompanied by agile risk management, strong governance, and a trusted, motivated workforce. Leaders in the TMT sector are uniquely positioned to integrate these pieces by using data and their own foresight to steer innovation. Those who implement an 'always-on' risk intelligence framework will be able to adopt innovation with clear guardrails, work on strengthening stakeholder trust, across customers, regulators, and talent, and scale their operations across the globe with confidence.